

Answer All Questions Asked

Whenever you reply to an inquiry, try to answer all questions—stated and implied. A colleague or prospective customer's reaction to an incomplete reply is likely to be unfavorable. The customer may think the respondent is careless or is purposely trying to conceal a weak spot. In general, "omissions cast suspicions," whether you are answering an inquiry about your product or recommending a former employee for a new job. If you have no information on a particular question, say so clearly. If you have unfavorable information in answer to certain questions, handle your reply with both tact and honesty.

Look for questions: some may even appear buried within a paragraph. Locate them and then answer precisely.

In one example, a software distributor, when replying to a dealer's letter, answered only four of seven questions. Because the original questions were unnumbered and somewhat buried in five long paragraphs, the respondent apparently overlooked or disregarded three of them. The reply, incomplete and unfriendly, caused the distributor to lose the business and goodwill of a potential customer.

Sometimes before you can answer an inquiry, you need certain specific information from the inquirer. If so it is a good idea to list the needed details on a reply form that the inquirer can fill out and return to you. In this way both your answer and that of your respondent will be complete.

Give Something Extra, When Desirable

The words "when desirable," in the above heading, are essential. Sometimes you must do more than answer the customers' specific questions. They may not

■ Communication Probe

Credibility of the communicator has been systematically analyzed over the years, often as relating to the speaker. Several classic, but still relevant, studies suggest that five decisions are made regarding a communication source:

- Competence: Does the sender of the message know his or her message?
- Character: Does the audience perceive the message sender as communicating honestly?
- Composure: Does the sender give the impression of being calm and collected, particularly in a stressful situation?
- Sociability: Does the sender come across as a likable individual?
- Extroversion: Does the source exhibit outgoing tendencies rather than timidity?

McCroskey, J. C., Holridge, W. & Tromb, J. K. (1974). An instrument for measuring the source credibility of basic speech communication instructors. *Speech Teacher*, 23, 26-33; McCroskey, H. C., Jensen, T. & Todd, C. (1972). The generalizability of source credibility scales for public figures. *Paper, Speech Communication Association*, Chicago; McCroskey, J. C., Jensen, T., Todd, C. & Tromb, J. K. (1972), and many others.

know what they need, or their questions may be inadequate. For example, suppose you are president of your local Rotary Club and receive the following inquiry from an out-of-town member:

I'm new to the city and would like to consider joining your club. As I will be visiting your club within the month, will you please tell me where the next meeting will be held?

Use your good judgment in offering additional material if the sender's message was incomplete.

If you answered only this one question, your letter would be incomplete. Realizing that your reader is a newcomer to your city and to your Rotary Club, you should include in your reply a welcome plus such needed details as directions for reaching the building; parking facilities; day, date, and time of meeting; and perhaps also the program for the next meeting. Your message will then have the "something extra" that a reader really needs and appreciates. In most cases the reason the communicator includes something extra will be obvious; whenever it is not completely clear, explain why you are including the additional information.

Here are some additional examples of incomplete questions in faxes and one letter.

FAX 1 Incomplete question.

Please fax me in return the departures from Singapore to Hong Kong on the 8th.

In responding to the above you would have to "give something extra" as to times of day, airlines flying that route, costs, and departure and arrival times.

FAX 2 Incomplete question.

How come my request for an interview letter did not receive a response?

When was letter sent? Who sent it? To whom was it sent? In other words, to answer fax 2 would require a return letter or fax seeking answers to the above questions.

LETTER 1 Incomplete letter to a new savings depositor.

Thank you for the confidence you have shown us by the account you recently opened.

All our facilities are at your disposal, and any time we can be of service, please call on us. Our appreciation is best expressed by our being of service to you.

LETTER 1 *Revised, complete letter to the new savings depositor*

Thank you for the confidence you have shown in First Federal by the savings account you recently opened. Our goal is to make all our services to you both pleasant and helpful.

Among the conveniences and services available to you at First Federal, you may be especially interested in these:

YOUR PASSBOOK DEPOSITS earn $6\frac{1}{2}\%$ interest, compounded monthly.

BETTER-THAN-CHECKING service helps you pay bills by phone, earns interest on your money, and permits using our 24-hour cash machines.

MORTGAGE LOANS help you to buy, build, or refinance a home or to borrow for property repairs and improvements.

With our MONEY MARKET CERTIFICATES you can earn interest at various current high rates, depending on time and amount of your investment. The enclosed leaflet gives you more details about these and other services available to you at First Federal.

FREE CUSTOMER PARKING is provided in the lot north of our office. The teller stamps your parking slip, entitling you to free parking while doing business here. Office hours are 9:30 A.M. to 4:30 P.M. weekdays except for Friday, when the doors remain open until 6:00 P.M.

You are most welcome to come in whenever we can assist you. Please consider this association your financial headquarters for your savings and borrowing needs.

Checklist 2.1 Completeness

1. Remember the five W's:
Who? What? When? Where? Why?
2. Answer all questions:
 - a. Stated questions from questioner.
 - b. Implied questions from questioner.
3. Give extra information, when desirable.

■ Communication Probe

Completeness means that you tell your reader what he or she wants to know about your service or product. It involves laying out the benefits of what you are selling; it means imagining every reader to have a "show me" attitude. Readers must be convinced; they have to be shown results from simple reading. Therefore writers must be thorough. Informative selling will give the buyer confidence and increase later satisfaction with the purchased product or service. Such completeness will also reduce the number of goods returned to the firm.

On writing a sales letter. (ND). *Royal Bank of Canada*, 43, 3.

CONCISENESS

Conciseness is saying what you have to say in the fewest possible words without sacrificing the other C qualities. A concise message is complete without being wordy.

Conciseness is a prerequisite to effective business communication. A concise message saves time and expense for both sender and receiver. Conciseness contributes to emphasis; by eliminating unnecessary words, you let important ideas stand out. When combined with a "you-view," concise messages are inherently more interesting to recipients. Finally, concise messages show respect for recipients by not cluttering their professional lives with unnecessary information.

To achieve conciseness, observe the following suggestions:

- Eliminate wordy expressions.
- Include only relevant material.
- Avoid unnecessary repetition.

Eliminate Wordy Expressions

The following are some concrete suggestions you can use to reduce wordiness in your communication.

1. Use single-word substitutes instead of phrases whenever possible without changing meanings.

Use single words in place of phrases. Even Winston Churchill made extensive use of simple, one syllable words.

Wordy: At this time
Concise: Now

Wordy: Due to the fact that
Concise: Because

Wordy: Have need for
Concise: Need

Wordy: In due course
Concise: Soon

2. Omit trite, unnecessary expressions.

Wordy: Please be advised that your admission statement was received.
Concise: Your admission statement has been received.

Wordy: Allow me to say how helpful your response was.
Concise: Your last response was helpful.

3. Replace wordy conventional statements with concise versions.

Wordy: Please find attached the list you requested.
Concise: The list you requested is attached.

Wordy: Such refreshing comments are few and far between.
Concise: Such refreshing comments are scarce.

4. Avoid overusing empty phrases.

Wordy: It was known by Mr. Smith that we must reduce inventory.
Concise: Mr. Smith knew we must reduce inventory.

Wordy: There are four rules that should be observed.
Concise: Four rules should be observed.

5. Omit "which" and "that" clauses whenever possible.

Wordy: She bought desks that are of the executive type.
Concise: She bought executive-type desks.

Wordy: The receipt that is enclosed documents your purchase.
Concise: The enclosed receipt documents your purchase.

Use your computer grammar check or let someone else check whether you have overused certain words; dullness may result from the same word or idea being repeated too often.

6. Eliminate unnecessary prepositional phrases.

Wordy: The issue of most relevance is teamwork.
Concise: The most relevant issue is teamwork.

Wordy: In most cases the date of the policy is indicated in the upper right corner.
Concise: The policy date is in the upper right corner.

7. Limit use of the passive voice.

Wordy: The total balance due will be found on page 2 of this report.
Concise: The balance due is on page 2 of this report.

Wordy: The reports are to be submitted by employees prior to 5:00, at which time they will be received by Mr. Jones.
Concise: Please submit your reports to Mr. Jones by 5:00.

In all attempts to reduce wordiness, you must be careful to not distort meaning. Conciseness reflects the thoughtful elimination of unnecessary words.

Only Relevant Material

The effective, concise message should omit not only unnecessarily wordy expressions but also irrelevant statements. To be sure you include only relevant facts, observe the following suggestions.

1. Stick to the purpose of the message.
2. Delete irrelevant words and rambling sentences.

Communication Probe

Wordiness has been the bane of writers—and speakers—since humans began to communicate. The word used to describe such circumlocution is *tautology*, or using two or more words to express a simple and single thought. Often we have implied that business communication can be dull; it tends to lack modifiers, it avoids excessive use of superfluous—or should—words. Yet, writers of reports or other forms of communication should follow the maxim, “once is often enough.”

Alexander, D. & Rivett, A. (1995, Spring). Once is often enough. *Journal of Management Consulting*, 8, 32.

2. When you want to stress the object of the action. In "Your savings account is insured up to \$100,000," you have intentionally stressed "your account"—not the firm that does the insuring. Also, "You are invited" is better than "We invite you."
3. When the doer isn't important in the sentence. In "Three announcements were made before the meeting started," the emphasis is on the announcements, not on who gave them.

Put Action in Verbs, Not in Nouns

Verbs propel thought; they move ideas in place of slower-moving nouns.

Seven verbs—*be, give, have, hold, make, put, and take*—(in any tense) might be designated as "deadly" when the action they introduce is hidden in a "quiet noun." The examples below show how each deadly verb with the noun and preposition (all underlined) can be changed to an action verb that shortens the sentence.

Action Hiding in a "Quiet" Noun Action in the Verb

The function of this office is the collection of payments and the compilation of statements.

This office collects payments and compiles statements.

Professor H. will give consideration to the report.

Professor H. will consider the report.

The proposal has a requirement for . . .

The proposal requires that . . .

Students held the meeting in the office.

Students met in the office.

Put Action in Verbs, Not in Infinitives

Action Hiding in Infinitive

The duty of a secretary is to check all incoming mail and to record it. In addition, it is his or her responsibility to keep the assignment book up to date.

Action in the Verb

A secretary checks and records all incoming mail and keeps the assignment book up to date.

Choose Vivid, Image-Building Words

Business writing uses less figurative language than does the world of fiction.

Among the devices you can use to make your messages forceful, vivid, and specific are sensory appeals, comparisons, figurative language, concrete nouns, and well-chosen adjectives and adverbs. But use these devices with caution: business writing uses fewer descriptors than does a magazine article or fictional writing.

3. Omit information obvious to the receiver; do not repeat at length what that person has already told you. If you feel it is important to remind the audience of known information, subordinate the familiar information.
4. Avoid long introductions, unnecessary explanations, excessive adjectives and prepositions, pompous words, gushy politeness.
5. Get to the important point tactfully and concisely.

Wordy: We hereby wish to let you know that our company is pleased with the confidence you have reposed in us.

Concise: We appreciate your confidence.

Wordy: At this time I am writing to you to enclose an interview card, which has been post-paid, for the purpose of arranging a convenient time when we might get together for a personal interview.

Concise: Please return the enclosed interview card to set up a convenient time for an interview.

Avoid Unnecessary Repetition

Unnecessary repetition leads to dullness.

Sometimes repetition is necessary for emphasis. But when the same thing is said two or three times without reason, the message becomes wordy and boring. Here are three ways to eliminate unnecessary repetition:

1. Use a shorter name after you have mentioned the long one once. Instead of the "North Central Company," use "North Central."
2. Use pronouns or initials rather than repeat long names. Instead of citing "American Association of Technical Analysts" again and again, use "it" or "they" or AATA. When using well-known initials or acronyms, give the full reference first with the initials in parentheses: The North American Free Trade Agreement (NAFTA) is being debated in Congress.
3. Cut out all needless repetition of phrases and sentences. Sometimes it is possible to combine two or even more sentences by using subordinate clauses or phrases.

The following letter from a business executive to a firm the company had dealt with for 5 years shows unnecessary repetition at its worst.

Wordy: Will you ship us sometime, anytime during the month of October would be fine, or even November if you are rushed (November would suit us just as well, in fact a little bit better) 300 of the regular 3- by 15-inch blue felt arm-bands with white sewn letters in the center.

■ Checklist 2.2 Conciseness

1. Use one word in place of phrases; one sentence in place of two. Read out loud to "listen" for wordiness.
2. Omit outdated trite expressions.
3. Ask yourself: What material is really relevant?
4. Look for unnecessary repetition: Does the same word or idea appear too often?

Thank you in advance for sending these along to us by parcel post, and not express, as express is too expensive.

Concise: Please ship parcel post, before the end of November, 300 regular 3- by 15-inch blue felt armbands with white sewn letters in the center.

CONSIDERATION

Consideration means preparing every message with the message receivers in mind; try to put yourself in their place: You are considerate, you do not lose your temper, you do not accuse, you do not charge them without facts. You are, foremost, aware of their desires, problems, circumstances, emotions, and probable reactions to your request. Then handle the matter from their point of view. This thoughtful consideration is also called "you-attitude," empathy, the human touch, and understanding of human nature.

In a broad but true sense, consideration underlies the other six C's of good business communication. You adapt your language and message content to your receiver's needs when you make your message complete. Three specific ways to indicate consideration are:

- Focus on "you" instead of "I" and "we."
- Show audience benefit or interest in the receiver.
- Emphasize positive, pleasant facts.

Focus on "You" Instead of "I" or "We"

Using "you" does help project a you-attitude. But overuse can lead to a negative reaction.

To create considerate, audience-oriented messages, focus on how message receivers will benefit, what they will receive, and what they want or need to know. In some cases, this can be accomplished by emphasis; you might downplay your own feelings and emphasize a point, make an explicit reference, or use a direct quotation in responding to the request of another individual. Creating a you-attitude may require avoiding telling others how they feel, assuming you know their needs.

We-Attitude: I am delighted to announce that we will be extending our hours to make shopping more convenient.

You-Attitude: You will be able to shop evenings with the extended hours.

We-Attitude: We're sure you must be frustrated by the length of time it has taken to ship your order for Polish gargoyles.

You-Attitude: The Polish gargoyles you ordered will reach you within a week.

Showing consideration for the audience involves more than just using "you" instead of "I" or "we." Messages that use "we" can be receiver-oriented if "we" includes the recipient of the message. Messages that use "you" can be insensitive in negative situations. In fact, sometimes avoiding "you" can reduce potential defensiveness or allow the recipient to save face. An extreme example of a negative situation is the collection letter with "you" or "your" in almost every sentence; if those sentences are insulting, sarcastic, tactless, or untrue accusations and threats against the debtor, the letter surely lacks a you-attitude. The use of "you" in negative situations can be avoided by employing the passive voice, making the receiver part of a group, or depersonalizing the situation.

Insensitive: You failed to enclose your check in the envelope.

Considerate: The check was not enclosed. [*passive voice*]

Considerate: The envelope we received did not have a check in it. [*depersonalized*]

Insensitive: Your contract tells you plainly that . . .

Considerate: I'm always happy to discuss the contract terms with new employees. [*receiver as part of group*]

Insensitive: You are completely off base in your proposal.

Considerate: We have differing interpretations of the utility of the proposal. [*sender-oriented with acceptance of responsibility*]

Considerate: The proposed plan has three aspects that need clarification. [*depersonalized*]

Show Audience Benefit or Interest in the Receiver

Readers may react positively when benefits are shown them.

Whenever possible and true, show how your receivers will benefit from what ever the message asks or announces. Benefits must meet recipients' needs, address their concerns, or offer them rewards. Most important, they must be perceived as benefits by the receivers. This means that you must identify the

legitimate benefits of your position, policy, or product and then put yourself in the place of the receivers to assess their perspectives.

Receivers will be more likely to react favorably and do what you suggest if you show that benefits are worth the effort and cost you ask of them. In situations where actual direct benefit is impossible or irrelevant to the subject matter, the message should at least show interest in and concern for the recipient's needs or viewpoints.

Merely inserting the word "you" does not ensure you-attitude, as shown in this sentence: "You will be glad to know that we now have a walk-up window open 7-9 A.M. and 3-8 P.M. every weekday." Some readers wonder, "So what?" The following revised sentence includes reader benefit: "You can now take care of your banking needs at our new Walk-Up Window. It is open with a capable teller to serve you 7-9 A.M. and 3-8 P.M. Monday through Friday."

Reader-benefit appeals help collect payments on bills, soften the blow in a turndown, and sell products. Such appeals are desirable also in job applications, favor requests, and announcements to your customers, prospective buyers, stockholders, and employees. Whether you are writing to one person or to large numbers, try to personalize the reader benefits instead of stating them in a general way. Benefits that are realistic, inherent, and tailored to individuals help communicators achieve goals in effective, ethical ways.

Emphasize Positive, Pleasant Facts

A third way to show consideration for your receivers is to accent the positive. This means stressing what can be done instead of what cannot be done, and focusing on words your recipient can consider favorably.

Negative—Unpleasant

It is impossible to open an account for you today.

We don't refund if the returned item is soiled and unsalable.

When you travel on company expense, you will not receive approval for first-class fare.

Positive—Pleasant

As soon as your signature card reaches us, we will gladly open an . . .

We refund when the returned item is clean and resalable.

When you travel on company expense, your approved fare is for tourist class.

Because of past connections with words, readers will react positively or negatively to certain words.

Among the *positive* words to which people react favorably are *benefit, cordial, happy, help, generous, loyal, pleasure, thanks, thoughtful*. Words with *negative* connotations that often arouse unfavorable reactions include *blame, complaint, failed, fault, negligence, regret, reject, trouble, unfair*, and many others. For example, in the following opening of a letter the negative words (underlined) focus on ideas you'd rather not have the reader think about.

We regret that, since you closed your account, your name will be missing from our long list of satis-

Checklist 2.3 Consideration

1. See your material from your reader's point of view.
2. "You" is more desirable than "I" or "we" in most instances.
3. Readers like to see benefits. Be sure benefits are a prominent part of the message.
4. Consciously use positive words: readers will react more favorably.

fied customers. We sincerely hope that, despite the best efforts of our fine staff, there were no occasions on which you felt we failed to serve you properly.

As a final note, true consideration is a result of integrity and ethics in communication. Because the topic of ethics and communication is so important, we treat it in a separate chapter.

CONCRETENESS

misunderstandings of words have produced tragedies in both war and peace, in business and nonbusiness situations.

Communicating *concretely* means being specific, definite, and vivid rather than vague and general. Often it means using denotative (direct, explicit, often dictionary-based) rather than connotative words (ideas or notions suggested by or associated with a word or phrase). Thus the term *female* may appear in a personnel folder as a part of a job description, yet widely different connotations may occur when using terms as *wife*, *mother*, *spinster*, *widow*, *maiden*, *matron*, or *dowager*. Each of these latter terms also refers to *female* but with wide-ranging associations.

Communication Probe

Some letter writers are completely absorbed in the things about which they are writing, about quantities and qualities, about dollars and delivery. To become intelligible and effective, they need to enrich their thoughts by spreading them out to include people. At the core of good writing is audience analysis, audience adaptation.

Some persons will say that business is objective, mechanical, dealing with commodities and services rather than with people. How absurd it is to say so when every businessperson knows that every sale, every purchase, every contact, every financial deal, depends upon the word "yes" or "no" from some human being.

On Writing Clearly. (ND). Royal Bank of Canada Letter, 38, 7.

The benefits to business professionals of using concrete facts and figures are obvious: your receivers know exactly what is required or desired. Using concrete language has some additional, less obvious advantages. When you supply specifics for the reader or listener, you increase the likelihood that your message will be interpreted the way you intended. Moreover, concrete messages are more richly textured than general or vague messages; thus, they tend to be more vivid, dynamic, and interesting. The following guidelines should help you compose concrete, convincing messages.

- Use specific facts and figures.
- Put action in your verbs.
- Choose vivid, image-building words.

Use Specific Facts and Figures

It is desirable to be precise and concrete in both written and oral business communication.

Whenever possible, use an exact, precise statement or a figure in place of a general word to make your message more concrete.

Vague, General, Indefinite

Student GMAT scores are higher.

Eastern Europe is making progress in obtaining investments.

She's a brain.

Concrete, Precise

In 1996 the GMAT scores averaged 600; by 1997 they had risen to 610.

In 1990 investments in Eastern Europe were about US \$30 million; today that figure has increased by 12%.

Her grade-point average in 1996 was 3.9 on a four-point scale.

Note in the above examples that some of the vague words are opinion words. What is *higher*? What do we mean by *progress*? What does being a *brain* mean?

For example, the following words can also lead to uncertainty, confusion:

slightly	small	soon	early	high	about
most	a few	slow	very	almost	several

Of course it is permissible—even desirable—to use general expressions. But note some exceptions to the “facts and figures” rule:

1. When it is not possible to be specific: “You may not have the precise figures or facts.”
2. When you wish to be diplomatic (considerate): “You have missed three invitations to my office” is harsh; you may be more tactful by saying “I’ve sent you several reminders to see me in my office.”
3. When exact figures are unimportant, as in “more than half the committee was present.”

Put Action in Your Verbs

Verbs can activate other words and help make your sentences alive, more vigorous. That is, to have dynamic sentences (1) use active rather than passive verbs and (2) put action in your verbs rather than in nouns and infinitives.

Use the Active Voice

When the subject performs the action described by the verb, the verb is said to be in the active voice. Usually the active voice puts the verb up front. "The financial officer *reported* to the Board." Here the subject (the financial officer) reported; the verb "reported" is active, is up front in the sentence.

Conversely, when the subject receives the action of the verb, the verb is in the passive voice: ("The report by the financial officer was heard by the Board.") A passive verb has three characteristics:

- The subject does not do the acting in a sentence.
- The verb consists of two or more words, one of which is in some form of "to be" (is, is being, am, are, was, were, will be, has, or have been, had been, or will have been).
- The word "by" is expressed or implied (by whom or what).

Passive (Subject Receives the Action)

The tests were administered by the professors. Professors administered the tests.

Grades of students will be sent to you by the school. The school will send students their grades.

Active (Subject Performs the Action)

the subject acts there
the life, vividness.

Active verbs help make your sentences more

1. *Specific.* "The dean decided" is more explicit than "A decision has been made."
2. *Personal.* "You will note" is both personal and specific; "It will be noted" is impersonal.
3. *Concise.* The passive requires more words and thus slows both writing and reading. Compare "Figures show" with "It is shown by figures."
4. *Emphatic.* Passive verbs dull action. Compare "The students held a contest" with "A contest was held by the students."

Sometimes, however, you may prefer the passive voice instead of the active, as in the following situations:

1. *When you want to avoid personal, blunt accusations or comments.* "The October check was not included" is more tactful than "You failed to include. . . ." "Attendance at the meeting is required" is less harsh than "You must attend. . . ."

2. When you want to stress the object of the action. In "Your savings account is insured up to \$100,000," you have intentionally stressed "your account"—not the firm that does the insuring. Also, "You are invited" is better than "We invite you."
3. When the doer isn't important in the sentence. In "Three announcements were made before the meeting started," the emphasis is on the announcements, not on who gave them.

Put Action in Verbs, Not in Nouns

Verbs propel thought; they move ideas in place of slower-moving nouns.

Seven verbs—*be*, *give*, *have*, *hold*, *make*, *put*, and *take*—(in any tense) might be designated as "deadly" when the action they introduce is hidden in a "quiet noun." The examples below show how each deadly verb with the noun and preposition (all underlined) can be changed to an action verb that shortens the sentence.

Action Hiding in a "Quiet" Noun

The function of this office is the collection of payments and the compilation of statements.

Professor H. will give consideration to the report.

The proposal has a requirement for . . .

Students held the meeting in the office.

Action in the Verb

This office collects payments and compiles statements.

Professor H. will consider the report.

The proposal requires that . . .

Students met in the office.

Put Action in Verbs, Not in Infinitives

Action Hiding in Infinitive

The duty of a secretary is to check all incoming mail and to record it. In addition, it is his or her responsibility to keep the assignment book up to date.

Action in the Verb

A secretary checks and records all incoming mail and keeps the assignment book up to date.

Choose Vivid, Image-Building Words

Business writing uses less figurative language than does the world of fiction.

Among the devices you can use to make your messages forceful, vivid, and specific are sensory appeals, comparisons, figurative language, concrete nouns, and well-chosen adjectives and adverbs. But use these devices with caution: business writing uses fewer descriptors than does a magazine article or fictional writing.

Checklist 2.4 Concreteness

1. Were you precise in using facts and figures wherever possible?
2. Did you use the active voice more than the passive?
3. Is there action in verbs rather than in nouns or infinitives?
4. Did you try to occasionally use vivid, image-building words? But in business writing, use them sparingly.

Sensory Appeal

Concrete language often evokes a sensory response in people; it appeals to one or more of the five senses. Such language tends to be more descriptive than conventional business language. For example, instead of saying "It was hot in the factory," you might appeal to both sight and touch by saying "Sweat trickled down the arms of the line workers"; or "The secretary's face was wrinkled after squinting into the computer the entire day." Although sensory appeals are used primarily in marketing products, they also have a limited place in providing color and specificity in other forms of business communication.

Comparisons

Analogies (either figurative or literal) or comparisons can make an unclear idea clear or make an idea more vivid. Compare the bland images in the left column with those in the right column:

Bland Image

Proposals submitted this quarter were uninteresting.

This is a long letter.

More Vivid Image

Too many simple sentences, too many simplistic ideas, gave the impression of the writing of a first-year student.

This letter is three times as long as you said it would be.

Figurative Language

Use figures of speech with caution. When used sparingly they do make an idea more vivid. Consider the following three examples.

Literal (and Dull)

Her work in groups was exemplary.

Some women were stopped in their promotions.

More Vivid, Figurative

She could be called "the spark plug of the group."

Many women faced the "glass ceiling" in the company.

■ Communication Probe

In the ancient world, rhetoricians (teachers of oral communication) suggested that ornateness in language was a significant part of communication. Indeed, there were communication practitioners and theorists who argued that ornateness in words and their use within a sentence were core to effective communication.

Such heavy emphasis on ornate communication slowly disappeared in communication texts in the Renaissance and later. Organization of ideas, support for those ideas replaced the micro divisions and subdivisions of how to be more ornate in communication. Today ornateness in communication is more characteristic of honorary degree citations or keynote speeches at political conventions. Metaphors (implied comparisons between two things) are modern day uses of figures of speech thoroughly discussed in ancient communication texts. Business communication today uses few forms of ornateness.

Hildebrandt, H. W. (1988). Some influences of Greek and Roman rhetoric on early letter writing. *The Journal of Business Communication*, 25(3), 7-26.

Literal (and Dull)

Our budget analysis will begin soon.

More Vivid, Figurative

This is the first shot across your bow as we begin to review your budget for next year.

CLARITY

Getting the meaning from your head into the head of your reader—*accurately*—is the purpose of *clarity*. Of course, you know this is not simple. We all carry around our own unique interpretations, ideas, experiences associated with words.

- Choose precise, concrete and familiar words.
- Construct effective sentences and paragraphs.

Choose Precise, Concrete, and Familiar Words

Clarity is achieved in part through a balance between precise language and familiar language. When you use precise or concrete language, you select exactly the right word to convey your meaning. Precise words need not be pretentious. When you use familiar language, you select a word that is part of your personal repertoire, familiar to the audience, and appropriate for the situation. Familiar words, as between two good friends, for example, are often conversational, and occasionally may be part of a speech or written communication.

When you have a choice between a long word and a short one, use the short, familiar word that your reader or listener will quickly understand. Also, use synonyms instead of Latin terms (L) if they, though short, may be unfamiliar to your audience.

In doubt, use more familiar words; audiences will understand them better.

Familiar

about
after
home
for example
pay
invoice

Pretentious

circa (L)
subsequent
domicile
e.g. (L)
remuneration
statement for payment

Notice how the following statement with unfamiliar words is expressed clearly in the revision using familiar words.

Unfamiliar: After our perusal of pertinent data, the conclusion is that a lucrative market exists for the subject property.

Familiar: The data we studied show that your property is profitable and in high demand.

Although it is appropriate to use technical terms and business jargon in some professional situations, avoid it when you communicate with a person who is not acquainted with the terminology. If you must use such terms, define them briefly and clearly. If you don't, you'll confuse, embarrass, or irritate the reader. You may even be forced to explain later, as in the following classic story:

A plumber wrote the National Bureau of Standards to tell them hydrochloric acid is good for cleaning out clogged drains. (Before you go any further into the story, visualize the plumber. Assume you don't know him and have never exchanged correspondence. It is a pretty good guess he isn't a college graduate—maybe he didn't finish high school. But he probably is a good plumber—at least conscientious—because he's writing to the bureau to tell them something he thinks will help other people.)

In reply to the plumber's message, a technical specialist of the bureau wrote:

The efficacy of hydrochloric acid is indisputable, but the corrosive residue is incompatible with metallic permanence.

The plumber then wrote to thank the bureau for agreeing with him—when, of course, the bureau was actually disagreeing with him. Sensing the plumber didn't understand, another member tried to set the man straight by writing:

We cannot assume responsibility for the production of toxic and noxious residue with hydrochloric acid, and suggest you use an alternative procedure.

Again the plumber thanked the bureau. Then, in desperation, the department manager wrote:

Don't use hydrochloric acid. It eats hell out of the pipes.

As we have said and will say throughout the book, understanding the author helps writers choose familiar words those known by the speaker and the listener. Here are just a few examples.

Possibly Unfamiliar	Familiar to the Layperson
assessed valuation	property value for tax purposes
charge to your principal	increase the balance of your loan
easement for ingress and egress	allows passage in and out
buyouts	purchased by another company
scribblers' compacts	letters passed along to which readers added comments

With the increased use of E-mail there is the tendency to be concise. The danger is that you must know the meaning of the E-mail acronyms which aid conciseness. For instance how many of the following abbreviations do you know? IMO, FAQ, LOL, MOTOS. Respectively: in my opinion, frequently asked question, laughing out loud, member of the opposite sex.

Construct Effective Sentences and Paragraphs

At the core of clarity is the sentence. This grammatical statement, when clearly expressed, moves thoughts within a paragraph. Important characteristics to consider are length, unity, coherence, and emphasis.

Length

Generally, short sentences are preferred. The suggested average sentence length should be about 17 to 20 words. Because variety in sentence length adds interest to writing, adopt a range of from 3 to 30 or more words. But when a sentence exceeds 40 words, try to rewrite it into more than one sentence. Also, if all sentences are short (under 10 words), the result is primerlike language—choppy and overly simple.

Try for an average sentence length of between 17 and 20 words.

Unity

In a sentence—whether simple, compound, or complex—unity means that you have one main idea, and any other ideas in the sentence must be closely related to it. "I like Jim, and the Eiffel Tower is in Paris" obviously is not a unified sentence.

Coherence

In a coherent sentence the words are correctly arranged so that the ideas clearly express the intended meaning. Place the correct modifier as close as possible to the word it is supposed to modify. In the following examples notice why each "unclear" sentence conveys a wrong meaning, and how it is corrected in the "clear" sentence.

Communication Probe

A former assistant managing editor of the *New York Times*, Theodore Bernstein, summarized a series of studies in his classic book—*Watch Your Language*—concerned with one question: Why were some newspaper writers considered more understandable than their colleagues? On review of the newspaper stories, one fact stood out: The more understandable writer used more short sentences. One study compared a journal article with few sentences with the same story with many sentences.

Longer Sentence Version		Shorter Sentence Version	
Number of words	271		265
Total sentences	5		21
Average words			
Per sentence	54		12

After two groups of students took comprehension tests on what they had read, the shorter sentence version resulted in a comprehension level of 64 percent as against 9 percent in the longer sentence version.

Bernstein, T. (1958). *Watch your language* (p. 112). New York: Channel Press.

- Unclear: Being an excellent lawyer, I am sure you can help us.
- Clear: Being an excellent lawyer, you can surely help us.
- Clear: As you are an excellent lawyer, I am sure you . . .
- Unclear: His report was about managers, broken down by age and gender.
- Clear: His report focused on age and gender of managers.
- Clear: His report about managers focused on . . .
- Unclear: After planting 10,000 berry plants, the deer came into our botanist's farm and crushed them.
- Clear: After our botanist had planted 10,000 berry plants, the deer came into his farm and crushed them.

Emphasis

The quality that gives force to important parts of sentences and paragraphs is emphasis. Writers must decide what needs emphasis, and then choose correct sentence structure. In a complex sentence the main idea should be placed in the

most often, put main ideas first within a sentence.

Checklist 2.5 Clarity

1. Choose as precise or as concrete a word as possible.
2. Select words that have a high sense of appropriateness for the audience.
3. Opt for the familiar word, the one that is not pretentious.
4. Limit average sentence length to 17 to 20 words.
5. Insert no more than one main idea into a sentence.
6. Arrange words so that the main idea occurs early in a sentence.

main clause; the less important points are in subordinate (dependent) clauses or phrases.

For instance, in the first sentence below, the two ideas appear to be of equal value. In contrast, if the important idea is that the "airplane was difficult to control," the second sentence would be more meaningful and emphatic; its main idea is in the main clause.

Little emphasis:

The airplane finally approached the speed of sound, and it became very difficult to control.

Better emphasis:

As it finally approached the speed of sound, the airplane became very difficult to control.

Little emphasis:

Candidates should be motivated and have interest in static and dynamic testing of material, and have those prerequisites and others.

Better emphasis:

Prerequisites in candidates should include expertise in static and dynamic testing of material.

In addition to using the above methods for emphasis, the PCs of today—and related software—allow innumerable ways to visually add emphasis to words. Though it is impossible to list all of them, some visual procedures include: headings, tabulations, itemizations, graphs, line charts, pie charts, underlinings, italics, indentations, colored capitals or italics, or even wide or short margins. The visual innovations are endless.

COURTESY

Knowing your audience allows you to use statements of courtesy; be aware of your message receiver.

True *courtesy* involves being aware not only of the perspective of others, but also their feelings. Courtesy stems from a sincere you-attitude. It is not merely politeness with mechanical insertions of "please" and "thank you," although applying socially accepted manners is a form of courtesy. Rather, it is politeness that grows out of respect and concern for others.